Aviation Investigation Final Report

Location:	Gulf of America, Gulf of America	**Accident Number:**	DCA25LA091
Date & Time:	December 29, 2024, Local	**Registration:**	N647UA
Aircraft:	Boeing 767-322	**Aircraft Damage:**	None
Defining Event:	Turbulence encounter	**Injuries:**	1 Serious, 210 None
Flight Conducted Under:	Part 121: Air carrier - Scheduled		

Analysis

United Airlines flight 854, operating between George Bush Intercontinental / Houston Airport (IAH), Houston, Texas, and Jorge Chávez International Airport (LIM), Lima, Peru, encountered moderate turbulence while in cruise. One flight attendant sustained a serious injury during the turbulence encounter.

The captain served as the flying pilot and the first officer as the pilot monitoring for the entire flight. Prior to the flight, the crew reviewed the dispatch release and weather forecasts, which indicated areas of light to moderate turbulence along the route, and no other significant turbulence risks were identified along their route.

After a standard pushback, taxi, and takeoff, the aircraft climbed to cruise altitude. About one hour after reaching cruise altitude, the crew anticipated encountering turbulence ahead based on the SkyPath and Weather Services International (WSI) electronic depictions of turbulence potential along their route. The captain contacted the purser approximately ten minutes before the expected turbulence and advised that the “flight attendants, please take your jump seats” announcement would be made in five minutes. This was followed by a public announcement (PA) to passengers and crew regarding the expected turbulence and the need for flight attendants to be seated soon.

Five minutes later, the captain made the “flight attendants, please take your jump seats” PA to the cabin. Shortly thereafter, the aircraft encountered light turbulence that quickly escalated to moderate. The turbulence lasted approximately 25–30 minutes, with intermittent light turbulence continuing for an additional 15–20 minutes.

The three cabin crew members working in the rear of the aircraft reported that, following the “flight attendants, please take your jump seats” announcement, they attempted to move their service carts to the aft galley and secure their equipment. However, turbulence began before they could fully stow the carts, leaving them only able to park the carts in the galley without securing them back into their slots. While one flight attendant stated that while they were attempting to prevent a cart from tipping over, the airplane experienced a “big shake”. The flight attendant was thrown to the floor, striking her back against the edge of a jumpseat before falling to the floor. The flight attendant was able to secure themselves in a jumpseat for the remainder of the turbulence encounter.

Following the turbulence, the captain made a “flight attendants, please check in” PA, and the purser initially reported that all was well. However, later the purser informed the cockpit that a flight attendant had fallen in the aft galley during the turbulence. The captain visited the injured flight attendant, who reported lower back pain but stated they were fit to continue duties.

The crew contacted dispatch via satellite communications and given the flight attendant’s ability to continue working, they elected to continue to LIM without diversion and decided no further Medlink action was necessary. The approach and landing into Lima were normal.

After deplaning, the captain spoke with the injured flight attendant, who again declined medical attention, and was able to depart the flight and airport without assistance. However, when the injured flight attendant returned to Houston, the they were medically examined, and it was determined that they had sustained fractures of two vertebrae.

Probable Cause and Findings

The National Transportation Safety Board determines the probable cause(s) of this accident to be:

An encounter with an area of clear air turbulence during cruise, which resulted in a serious injury to a flight attendant.

Findings

Environmental issues	Clear air turbulence - Effect on personnel
Environmental issues	Clear air turbulence - Awareness of condition

Factual Information

History of Flight

Enroute-cruise	Turbulence encounter (Defining event)

Pilot Information

Certificate:	Airline transport	**Age:**	48,Male
Airplane Rating(s):	Single-engine land; Multi-engine land	**Seat Occupied:**	Left
Other Aircraft Rating(s):	None	**Restraint Used:**	
Instrument Rating(s):	Airplane	**Second Pilot Present:**	
Instructor Rating(s):	None	**Toxicology Performed:**	
Medical Certification:	Class 1 Without waivers/limitations	**Last FAA Medical Exam:**	November 12, 2024
Occupational Pilot:	Yes	**Last Flight Review or Equivalent:**	September 7, 2024
Flight Time:	20300 hours (Total, all aircraft), 1666 hours (Total, this make and model), 6600 hours (Pilot In Command, all aircraft), 96 hours (Last 90 days, all aircraft), 15 hours (Last 30 days, all aircraft)		

Co-pilot Information

Certificate:	Airline transport	**Age:**	31,Male
Airplane Rating(s):	Single-engine land; Multi-engine land	**Seat Occupied:**	Right
Other Aircraft Rating(s):	None	**Restraint Used:**	
Instrument Rating(s):	Airplane	**Second Pilot Present:**	
Instructor Rating(s):	Airplane single-engine	**Toxicology Performed:**	
Medical Certification:	Class 1 With waivers/limitations	**Last FAA Medical Exam:**	June 7, 2024
Occupational Pilot:	Yes	**Last Flight Review or Equivalent:**	July 23, 2024
Flight Time:	4479 hours (Total, all aircraft), 250 hours (Total, this make and model), 1969 hours (Pilot In Command, all aircraft), 36 hours (Last 90 days, all aircraft)		

Aircraft and Owner/Operator Information

Aircraft Make:	Boeing	**Registration:**	N647UA
Model/Series:	767-322	**Aircraft Category:**	Airplane
Year of Manufacture:	1992	**Amateur Built:**	
Airworthiness Certificate:	Transport	**Serial Number:**	25284
Landing Gear Type:	Retractable -	**Seats:**	330
Date/Type of Last Inspection:	February 4, 2024 Continuous airworthiness	**Certified Max Gross Wt.:**	412000 lbs
Time Since Last Inspection:		**Engines:**	2 Turbo fan
Airframe Total Time:	128296 Hrs at time of accident	**Engine Manufacturer:**	P&W
ELT:	Installed, not activated	**Engine Model/Series:**	PW4060
Registered Owner:	UNITED AIRLINES INC	**Rated Power:**	62000 Lbs thrust
Operator:	UNITED AIRLINES INC	**Operating Certificate(s) Held:**	Flag carrier (121)

Meteorological Information and Flight Plan

Conditions at Accident Site:	Visual (VMC)	**Condition of Light:**	Night
Observation Facility, Elevation:	MMUN	**Distance from Accident Site:**	
Observation Time:		**Direction from Accident Site:**	
Lowest Cloud Condition:	Scattered / 15000 ft AGL	**Visibility**	
Lowest Ceiling:	Broken / 25000 ft AGL	**Visibility (RVR):**	
Wind Speed/Gusts:	/	**Turbulence Type Forecast/Actual:**	/
Wind Direction:		**Turbulence Severity Forecast/Actual:**	/
Altimeter Setting:	29.96 inches Hg	**Temperature/Dew Point:**	
Precipitation and Obscuration:	No Obscuration; No Precipitation		
Departure Point:	Houston, TX (KIAH)	**Type of Flight Plan Filed:**	IFR
Destination:	Lima, Peru (SPJC)	**Type of Clearance:**	IFR
Departure Time:		**Type of Airspace:**	Class A

Wreckage and Impact Information

Crew Injuries:	1 Serious, 6 None	**Aircraft Damage:**	None
Passenger Injuries:	204 None	**Aircraft Fire:**	None
Ground Injuries:		**Aircraft Explosion:**	None
Total Injuries:	1 Serious, 210 None	**Latitude, Longitude:**	20.947128,-91.073273

Administrative Information

Investigator In Charge (IIC):	Bower, Daniel
Additional Participating Persons:	FAA representative ; FAA
Original Publish Date:	October 14, 2025
Last Revision Date:	
Investigation Class:	Class 4
Note:	The NTSB did not travel to the scene of this accident.
Investigation Docket:	https://data.ntsb.gov/Docket?ProjectID=199575

The National Transportation Safety Board (NTSB) is an independent federal agency charged by Congress with investigating every civil aviation accident in the United States and significant events in other modes of transportation—railroad, transit, highway, marine, pipeline, and commercial space. We determine the probable causes of the accidents and events we investigate, and issue safety recommendations aimed at preventing future occurrences. In addition, we conduct transportation safety research studies and offer information and other assistance to family members and survivors for each accident or event we investigate. We also serve as the appellate authority for enforcement actions involving aviation and mariner certificates issued by the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) and US Coast Guard, and we adjudicate appeals of civil penalty actions taken by the FAA.

The NTSB does not assign fault or blame for an accident or incident; rather, as specified by NTSB regulation, "accident/incident investigations are fact-finding proceedings with no formal issues and no adverse parties … and are not conducted for the purpose of determining the rights or liabilities of any person" (Title 49 *Code of Federal Regulations* section 831.4). Assignment of fault or legal liability is not relevant to the NTSB's statutory mission to improve transportation safety by investigating accidents and incidents and issuing safety recommendations. In addition, statutory language prohibits the admission into evidence or use of any part of an NTSB report related to an accident in a civil action for damages resulting from a matter mentioned in the report (Title 49 *United States Code* section 1154(b)). A factual report that may be admissible under 49 *United States Code* section 1154(b) is available here.